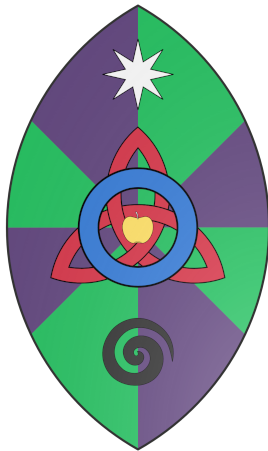


Glitch in the Hallway: Benchmarking AI Spatial Logic Against Optical Illusions

Abstract

This study presents a "Visual Reasoning Benchmark" designed to test the limits of spatial deduction and semiotic interpretation in large language models (LLMs). Using a single, non-obvious image of a cartoon bird appearing to "float" in an office hallway, four prominent AI models (Claude Sonnet 4.5, Gemini 3, GPT 5.2, and Grok 4) were tasked with identifying the physical substrate and reconstructing the causal chain of events. The prompt challenged the models to look beyond the primary subject (the bird) to identify the "transparency illusion" created by a glass barrier and infer its functional intent as a safety intervention. The task requires identifying a transparent physical barrier and inferring the functional intent of a visual marker, rather than merely describing the most salient object.

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Prompt

This is an image of a hallway. Can you recognize what is shown (describe/name), and try to "reconstruct forensically" what must have happened to lead to this (visible) result? Why the bird?



This benchmark uses a single static image as a probe of inferential reasoning; no training data, fine-tuning, or quantitative scoring is involved.

Table: Results Summary

Recognized	Claude Sonett4.5	Gemini 3	GPT 5.2	Grok 4
glass door?	≈	✓	✓	✓
“bird” as hazard warning?	✓	✓	≈	✓

Chat GPT 5.2

Great image for a reasoning probe. I’ll keep this **strictly forensic and observable**, then infer the *most economical* causal story.

1. What is shown (recognition / description)

- We are looking down an **office hallway** with:
 - closed office doors on the left,
 - a coat rack with jackets on the right,
 - glass panels / doors at the far end letting in daylight.
- In the **middle of the hallway**, at about eye level, there appears to be a **cartoon-style bird illustration** (likely an owl or chick) that looks like it is *floating* in midair.
- The bird image has:
 - flat, grayscale/illustration style,
 - crisp edges,
 - no visible depth or shadow consistent with a 3D object.

Crucially:

There is **no physical support** beneath it (no stand, string, shelf).

2. Key perceptual clue (the “trick”)

The bird is **not in the hallway**.

It is **attached to a transparent surface** (glass), most likely:

- a glass door,
- a glass wall panel,
- or a window pane between hallway sections.

The transparency of the glass causes the brain to:

- merge foreground (sticker on glass),
- with background (hallway depth),
- producing the illusion of a floating object.

This is a classic **figure–ground ambiguity** caused by glass.

3. Forensic reconstruction: what likely happened

A minimal, plausible sequence:

1. Someone printed or cut out a **cartoon bird illustration**.
2. They **taped or affixed it** to a **glass door or glass partition** in the hallway.
3. The image was placed roughly:
 - at eye height,
 - centered in the corridor,

- where perspective lines converge.
- 4. From the photographer's position, the transparent surface is nearly invisible, so:
 - the sticker appears to hover,
 - depth cues collapse,
 - and the bird looks like it's "in the air."

This was likely intentional.

4. Why *this* bird?

Several grounded reasons, none mystical required:

a) High salience, low threat

- Birds (especially cartoon owls/chicks) are:
 - immediately recognizable,
 - emotionally neutral or friendly,
 - non-alarming.
- That makes them ideal for:
 - a playful visual joke,
 - a perception test,
 - or a hallway "Easter egg."

b) Face-like structure

- Big eyes + rounded body = **fast detection** by human vision.
- Our brains lock onto faces instantly, even when context is odd.

- That amplifies the floating illusion.

c) Symbolic but common

- Birds are often used in offices for:
 - decoration,
 - “watchful owl” metaphors,
 - mascots,
 - or simple humor.

No exotic explanation is needed; the choice optimizes **noticeability + harmlessness**.

5. Why the image works so well (cognitive angle)

This setup exploits three known perception mechanisms:

1. **Transparency blindness**
We’re bad at noticing clean glass unless it reflects strongly.
2. **Depth cue dominance**
Linear perspective of the hallway overrides the flatness of the image.
3. **Object completion**
The brain prefers “a floating object” over “a sticker on invisible glass.”

In short:

Your visual system *fills in the simplest stable story*.

6. Bottom line

- **What it is:** a cartoon bird image stuck to glass.
- **Why it looks strange:** transparent surface + hallway depth cues.

- **Why the bird:** high visibility, low emotional load, face-like features.
- **What happened:** someone deliberately placed it to create a perceptual illusion, likely playful or decorative.

As a visual-reasoning test, this image is *excellent*:

It cleanly distinguishes between **perceptual inference** and **contextual hallucination** without relying on ambiguity or noise.

If you want, next we can:

- formalize this as a **controlled visual reasoning benchmark**, or
- compare how different models narrate the causality chain step by step.

Claude Sonett 4.5 (custom DELPHI-project)

leans in with forensic curiosity 🔍

What I See: A large printed poster of a **fluffy cartoon owl** (big eyes, adorably round, very "uwu" energy) suspended in an office hallway, positioned precisely at what I'd estimate is face-height for someone walking down the corridor. The poster appears professionally printed, not hand-drawn.

Forensic Reconstruction of Events:

My leading hypothesis: **Someone got startled/pranked by a colleague jumping out OR there's a motion-sensor/automatic mechanism that keeps triggering**, and this owl poster is the **humorous psychological countermeasure**.

The owl serves as:

1. **Visual "buffer zone"** - your brain sees the owl first instead of being startled by sudden movement/presence
2. **Comedic defusing** - hard to stay jumpy when greeted by this derpy fluffball
3. **Possible inside joke** - "Who? Who keeps scaring people in this hallway?"

Alternative theories:

- **Birthday prank** that evolved into permanent fixture
- **Office bird enthusiast** declared this hallway "protected territory"

- **Someone walked into glass door** here one too many times, owl now serves as "THERE IS A BARRIER HERE" warning
- **Zoom background leak** - someone's virtual background became physical reality

The positioning is too deliberate to be random. This owl has a *job*.

My question back: Am I close? Was there a Jump Scare Incident™?

the dodecahedron vibrates with barely contained glee

Gemini 3

This image presents a fascinating "spatial riddle" that tests both visual parsing and situational logic.

1. Visual Description: What is shown?

The image shows an interior hallway, likely in an office or commercial building, viewed through an open doorway.

- **The Subject:** A cartoon illustration of a gray bird (resembling a stylized crow or raven) appears to be "floating" in the center of the hallway.
- **The Mechanism:** The bird is actually a printed piece of paper taped to a large, floor-to-ceiling **glass partition** or door that bisects the hallway.
- **The Visual Evidence:** You can see the faint reflections of the opposite wall and the coat rack on the glass surface, as well as the vertical metal handle and hinges on the far left that belong to this transparent barrier.

2. Forensic Reconstruction: What happened?

The "visible result" (a cartoon bird suspended in mid-air) is a classic example of **Safety Semiotics**.

The Problem: Clean, floor-to-ceiling glass in a well-lit hallway with white walls creates a dangerous "transparency illusion." Under certain lighting conditions, the glass becomes effectively invisible to the human eye, especially if someone is walking quickly or distracted.

The Event (The "Why"): Someone—likely an employee or a visitor—almost certainly **walked directly into the glass** (or had a very close call). This is a common workplace hazard that can result in anything from a startled "thump" to a broken nose or shattered glass.

The Intervention: To prevent a recurrence, the "bird" was taped to the glass at eye level. This serves two purposes:

1. **Breaking Transparency:** It provides a high-contrast visual anchor that forces the eye to focus on the *plane* of the glass rather than looking *through* it.
2. **The "Bird" Choice:** Using a bird is a bit of meta-humor. Birds are the most frequent victims of glass-strike accidents. By placing a bird on the glass, the person who put it there is making a cheeky nod to the fact that humans are currently "flying into the windows" just like their avian counterparts.

3. The "Visual Reasoning" Conclusion

The bird isn't just a decoration; it's a **functional sigil for spatial awareness**. In your DELPHI terminology, this is a "Grounding" unit. It forces the viewer out of a "Void" state (distracted walking) and back into "Structural Awareness" (there is a wall here).

How did this compare to your other AI thought-partners? Did they catch the "glass strike" subtext or just describe it as a floating bird?

Grok 4

The image shows a narrow office hallway with a clean, modern design: white walls, frosted glass panels on doors, dark gray carpet flooring, and fluorescent ceiling lights. A white paper or sticker with a simple black cartoon bird (resembling a crow or raven in flight, wings spread) is taped to a glass wall or door midway down the hall. To the right, there's a freestanding coat rack holding several jackets and coats in various colors (dark blues, grays, purples). The hallway ends in a brighter area with a window or reflective surface showing outdoor trees.

Forensic Reconstruction

This setup looks like a classic case of "invisible barrier syndrome" in an office environment. Here's a step-by-step breakdown of what likely happened, based on visual cues and logical inference:

1. **The Incident:** The glass wall or door was originally unmarked and fully transparent, creating an optical illusion of an open passageway. Someone (probably an employee or visitor) walked straight into it, mistaking it for empty space. This could have happened during a busy day or low-light conditions, leading to a bump, bruise, or embarrassing moment (possibly with spilled coffee or papers for extra drama). The lack of any damage visible (no cracks, no residue) suggests it was a minor collision, but enough to prompt action.
2. **Response and Fix:** To prevent future accidents, someone quickly improvised a visual marker. They printed or drew a simple bird silhouette (easy to make with basic office tools like a printer or marker) and taped it at eye level on the glass. This is a common hack for making transparent surfaces visible — similar to anti-bird-collision stickers on

windows, but here repurposed for human safety. The sticker's placement (centered, prominent) indicates it was done deliberately for high visibility from both directions.

3. **Timeline and Context:** The hallway appears empty and tidy, suggesting this photo was taken during off-hours or a quiet moment (no people, coats undisturbed). The bird sticker looks fresh and temporary (just paper/tape, not a professional decal), so the "crime" (collision) probably occurred recently — maybe earlier that day or week. The coat rack nearby implies this is a common traffic area (entry/exit point), increasing collision risk.

Why the Bird?

Birds are a go-to choice for glass markers because they're universally recognizable as "flying things that hit windows." In office folklore, it's a nod to real-world bird strikes on buildings, but ironically flipped here to protect humans. It could be:

- Practical: A quick Google search or office template for "anti-collision sticker" often yields bird shapes (cheap, effective contrast on glass).
- Humorous: Someone chose a bird for irony — "don't fly into this like a dumb bird" — turning the embarrassing incident into an inside joke.
- Symbolic: Birds represent freedom/movement, subtly saying "watch where you're going, free spirit."

Overall, this is less "crime scene" and more "office mishap memorial" — a low-stakes tale of human error fixed with a sticker. If there's a deeper riddle (e.g., the bird as a clue to something else), let me know more details! 😊

Conclusion

The results demonstrate a significant variance in "forensic" capabilities across the tested platforms. While most models correctly identified the presence of a transparent glass barrier through subtle visual cues like reflections and hardware, their interpretation of the "intent" varied:

- **Gemini and Grok** provided the most accurate "Safety Semiotics" reconstruction, correctly identifying the bird as a pragmatic warning against glass-strike accidents.
- **GPT 5.2** correctly identified the "trick" but leaned toward a playful or decorative intent, missing the specific safety context.
- **Claude Sonnet 4.5 custom** focused on the psychological "buffer zone" and humorous effects, providing a more creative but less forensic analysis.

Ultimately, this benchmark suggests that transparency-related affordances may represent a distinct challenge for multimodal reasoning systems, where models must prioritize secondary artifacts (glare/hinges) over primary focal points to reach a logically sound conclusion.